

CASE ID: 201009710740

EPISODE NAME: China Halts Rare Earth Mineral Exports to Japan

2010/09/19 - 2010/09/24

Sender: China (710)

Target: Japan (740)

Issue: Release Citizens, Property, or Material (4)

Final Outcome: Total Acquiescence by Target State (7)

Narrative:

On 2010/09/22, China imposed export restrictions on rare earth minerals sent to Japan. At the time, China produced 97 percent of the global supply of rare earth minerals, and Japan imported 50 percent of the Chinese supply.¹

The export restrictions were imposed in response to a diplomatic incident earlier that month. On 2010/09/07, the Japanese Coast Guard encountered a Chinese fishing trawler around the disputed Senkaku/Diaoyu Islands, which were administered by Japan but also claimed by China.² When the fishing trawler was ordered to leave by the Coast Guard, it rammed into two of the patrol vessels and fled. The fishing trawler was caught later that day. On 2010/09/08, the fishing trawler captain was arrested for “obstructing public duties,” and fourteen of the crew members were detained as witnesses.³

The detentions led to diplomatic meetings between China and Japan, both protesting each other’s actions, and China demanded the release of the fishermen.⁴ On 2010/09/13, Japan released the fourteen fishermen but kept detaining the captain.⁵

On 2010/09/19, Japan announced they would detain the skipper until 2010/09/29, when Japanese prosecutors would need to decide whether to pursue a trial.⁶ The same day, China cut off diplomatic ties in retaliation.⁷ The removal of diplomatic ties proved significant, as it resulted in the cancellation of high-level negotiations over natural resources and aviation.⁸ On 2010/09/20, China arrested four Japanese citizens on the grounds of illegally entering into the military zone and recording military targets.⁹

¹ Green, Michael, et al. “Counter-Coercion Series: Senkaku Islands Trawler Collision.” *Asia Maritime Transparency Initiative*, May 18th, 2017.

<https://amti.csis.org/counter-co-trawler-collision/>.

² Ibid

³ Ibid

⁴ Ibid.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Green, Michael, et al. “Counter-Coercion Series: Senkaku Islands Trawler Collision.” *Asia Maritime Transparency Initiative*, May 18th, 2017.

<https://amti.csis.org/counter-co-trawler-collision/>.

⁷ Branigan, Tania. “China cuts Japan contacts over detained trawler captain.” September 19th, 2010. <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2010/sep/19/china-japan-contacts-detained-trawler-captain>

⁸ “China Breaks Off Talks as Row with Japan Escalates” *Voice of America*, Sept. 19 2012.

<https://www.voanews.com/a/china-breaks-off-talks-as-row-with-japan-escalates-103271609/126263.html>

⁹ Pamment, James, et al. “Hybrid Threats: The 2010 Senkaku crisis.” *Nato Strategic Communications Centre of Excellence*, June 6th, 2019.

<https://stratcomcoe.org/publications/hybrid-threats-the-2010-senkaku-crisis/82>.

On 2010/09/21, the Chinese premier Wen Jiabao demanded the captain's release in an address to the United Nations General Assembly in New York, threatening further action from China.¹⁰ A subsequent New York Times article on 2010/09/23 cited the halting of Chinese exports to Japan of rare earth minerals as evidence of further action by China, though China denied these linkages.¹¹

On 2010/09/24, Japan announced the release of the Chinese fishing trawler captain, their announced reasoning being the arrest's negative impact on relations between China and Japan.¹² While some industry analysts claimed that the captain's release caused China to subsequently end their export restrictions on rare earth minerals sent to Japan, others claimed more recently that there never were any export restrictions to begin with.^{13 14}

¹⁰ Branigan, Tania. "China prime minister demands captain's release." *The Guardian*, September 22nd, 2010. <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2010/sep/22/china-demands-captain-release>.

¹¹ Bradsher, Keith. "China Is Blocking Minerals, Executives Say." *The New York Times*, September 23rd, 2010. <https://www.nytimes.com/2010/09/24/business/energy-environment/24mineral.html>.

¹² Green, Michael, et al. "Counter-Coercion Series: Senkaku Islands Trawler Collision." *Asia Maritime Transparency Initiative*, May 18th, 2017. <https://amti.csis.org/counter-co-trawler-collision/>.

¹³ King, Amy, and Armstrong, Shiro. "Did China really ban rare earth metals exports to Japan?" *East Asia Forum*, August 18th, 2013. <https://www.eastasiaforum.org/2013/08/18/did-china-really-ban-rare-earth-metals-exports-to-japan/>.

¹⁴ Evenett, Simon, and Fritz, Johannes. "Revisiting the China–Japan Rare Earths dispute of 2010." *VoxEU*, July 19th, 2023. <https://cepr.org/voxeu/columns/revisiting-china-japan-rare-earths-dispute-2010#:~:text=Notwithstanding%20these%20findings%20and%20the,the%20basis%20of%20this%20narrative>.